

Rationalism



The pure reasoning of mathematics was a significant influence on the emergence of 17th-century rationalism.

Often known as the Age of Reason or Enlightenment, the 17th and 18th centuries were characterized by advances in knowledge through scientific reasoning, rather than faith or acceptance of conventional wisdom. In much of Europe, this manifested itself in the philosophical approach known as rationalism. Science, and mathematics in particular, inspired philosophers such as René Descartes, who argued that our senses are unreliable, so we

can understand the world through rational thought. This approach to epistemology, the way we acquire knowledge, echoed Plato's distrust of sensory perception (see [Plato's theory of Forms](#)). Descartes's rigorous approach marked a turning point in the history of philosophy, integrating mathematical method into philosophical enquiry. Rationalism was enthusiastically adopted by Spinoza and Gottfried Leibniz (both, significantly, accomplished mathematicians) and became the predominant school of philosophical thought in mainland Europe. In Britain, however, an opposing school of thought, empiricism, emerged from the same roots (see [Empiricism](#)).